

Cape Lookout Life Saving Station

When the lighthouse could not help a ship and it wrecked on the shoals anyway, the crew aboard the ships needed help to get to shore. This was the job of the Life Saving Service. Wrecks along Core Banks happened so often that three stations were built on it; one at Cape Lookout or the south end (1888), one halfway up the island, and the other at the North end of the island at Portsmouth.

The crews were busy around the clock with beach patrols, lookout duty and rescue drills practiced five days a week. On Saturdays, they had to clean the station.

One of the most famous wreck rescues at this station was the wreck of the ship, *Sarah D.J. Rawson*, in 1905. This vessel was loaded with lumber and wrecked on the outer shoals, about a couple of miles out in the ocean. When the wreck was discovered by Keeper Gaskill, he and his crew (surfmens Kilby Guthrie, Walter M. Yeomans, Tyre Moore, John A. Guthrie, James W. Fulcher, John H. Kirkman, Calupt T. Jarvis, and Joseph L. Lewis) were all sick with the flu...but they had to do their duty, so they manned the life boat and rowed the two miles out in the stormy ocean. When they arrived so much debris, ropes and lumber, were thrashing about in the raging ocean, they could not get close to the wreck. So they stayed in their small boat within sight of the helpless crew to give them hope that someone was coming to rescue them.. They stayed over 24 hours waiting for the ocean to calm, so they could get to the crew. Eventually, it did and they rescued six of the seven man crew. One man had been swept overboard before the Life Savers arrived. For this courageous and selfless rescue, Keeper Gaskill and his crew received the Life Saving Services highest award, the Gold Medal of Honor.

The Life Saving Service was eventually combined with the Lighthouse Service to form what we know today as the U.S. Coast Guard.



Photo of USLSS medal from
www.wheelmeon.org/obx2006.html

A Life-Saver

*He's a rigger, rower, swimmer, sailor, undertaker,
And he's good at every one of 'em the same,
And he risks his life for others in the quicksands and the breakers.
And a thousand wives and mothers bless his name.
He's an angel dressed in oilskins, he's a saint in a "sou'wester,
"He's as plucky as they make, or ever can.
He's a hero born and bred, but it hasn't swelled his head,
And he's jest the U.S. Government's hired man.*

poem by Joe Lincoln , Cape Cod native source: National Park Service U.S. Department of the Interior

